

System shock

AT A RECENT PRESS EVENT, I HAD THE PRIVILEGE OF SPEAKING TO SEVERAL KEY EXECUTIVES who were leading startups that use AI and ML to service the HR industry. There were several interesting products that these startups had to offer. One of them was very pro-employee since they identified upcoming market trends and then created courses for employees to reskill themselves so that not only are the employees up to date with the market but even the company is better equipped to stay ahead of the competition. Then there were some startups which were very much pro-employer. Their products could observe employee interaction to predict whether the employee was not satisfied or engaged, and was looking to put in their papers. These employees could then be approached and their concerns addressed. This is a great tool for employers who can easily identify “risks” and take steps to mitigate said risks but from the employee’s perspective, this is oddly invasive. This is exactly how the government of Oceania kept tabs on everyone in George Orwell’s dystopian novel 1984. At least INGSOC had the decency of letting the people know that they were being spied upon and didn’t do it in a sneaky fashion that this particular startup is doing. However, that’s not what I’m getting at.

Most of these startups had presence in multiple countries in different regions. Some of which were present in more than 50 countries. During my interaction with these executives, I asked them about their strategy for entering new countries. Since these startups were using AI/ML models at the core of their products, data was of utmost value as that’s how they could tweak their AI models to cater to these new countries. So they go where the data leads them. The answer was very predictable and obvious, but what happens when they don’t get enough data for tweaking? Most said they wouldn’t enter the country at that point in time. Now here’s where it matters.

The countries that don’t tend to have data are the ones that are underdeveloped and underserved. Places which are yet to undergo a “digital transformation journey”, if I’m to use industry parlance. Technology is seen as the great unifier, something that’s by nature destined to speed up a country’s or company’s or community’s or individuals’ development. Especially if there’s AI involved since that can accelerate the pace of development unlike any technology we’ve seen in the past. So when the great unifier, the builder of bridges

between the haves and the have nots, the blessing of silicon, etc. etc. refuses to enter a new country, then it has quite the opposite effect. Essentially that country grows at a normal pace (or reduced pace, depending on your frame of reference) while the ones around it develop much quicker. The gap between the haves and the have-nots widens and technology ends up being the great divider.

Eventually, this underserved and untouched-by-tech country will naturally evolve to a stage where it can benefit from the introduction of all the wonderful tech that startups have to offer but there’s a very good chance that it could be in for a shock. You see, this time gap has made the employment landscape in the underserved country increasingly polarised. And the rapid introduction of new technologies is going to create a job disruption like no other. A recent MIT Technology Review article elucidates this concept along the same lines, although I might have indulged in some reductio ad absurdum for dramatic effect. The MIT Technology Review article was focused on Asia in particular and went into how decision makers in Asia should be focused on evolving and reskilling or else the AI disruption would have a shocking impact to the system. This AI disruption is expected to eliminate 67.7 million jobs over the next 20 years in a developed nations such as the USA, as per an Oxford University study. It’s also expected to create a lot more jobs than that figure but if people aren’t reskilling in anticipation of this disruption, then you might as well airdrop pink slips onto the populace like they did during the two World Wars. The study explicitly states that less developed Asian economies are at greater risk of seeing higher job eliminations.

You don’t need me to point out the elephant in the room. It’s high time that people take matters into their own hands and focus on skilling themselves. Focus more on the jobs that are up and coming and prepare yourselves for the transition. Don’t expect someone to hand you a new job once your sector is disrupted by an AI startup, these things happen out of the blue and you will be blindsided. I’d be happy if the government started taking steps to mitigate the risks of a debilitating shock to the job landscape but I’d rather take action now.

“Then AI stretched out its hand over the people, and the AI Model drove the people back by a strong disruption and made the people jobless, and economies lay divided” – AI EXODUS 20:22 



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